



FOR ANNE GREGORY

English - Class 10 | Complete Comprehensive Study Notes

Author: W. B. Yeats

About the Author:

W. B. Yeats (William Butler Yeats) was an Irish poet and playwright, one of the greatest writers of the 20th century. In For Anne Gregory, he writes a short, thoughtful love poem about outer beauty versus inner self, using green and yellow hair, and God's love, as symbols.

1. Themes and Values

Theme:

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- The difference between physical beauty and inner self.
 - The idea that people often fall in love with looks or colour, not with the real person.
 - The idea that only God can love a person truly, beyond appearance.

Values:

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- Understanding that true love is for the inner self, not just for looks.

- Learning not to judge people by hair colour, clothes, or outer appearance.
- Respecting the soul and character more than physical beauty.
- Seeing that real, deep love is rare and special.

2. Stanza-wise Explanation

Stanza 1:

*Never shall a young man thrown into despair
By those great honey-coloured Ramparts at your ear.
Love you for yourself alone and not your yellow hair.*

→ In this stanza, the speaker says that no young man will ever fall into despair because of Anne's beautiful honey-coloured hair, described as honey-coloured ramparts. He also says that a young man may not love her for herself alone, but only for her yellow hair. This shows how people are often attracted to outer beauty rather than the real person.

Stanza 2:

*But I can get a hair-dye
And set such colour there,
Brown, or black, or carrot,
That young men in despair
May not love me for my hair,
But would perhaps love me for myself alone.*

→ Here, Anne speaks. She says she can change the colour of her hair using a dye - brown, black, or even carrot-red. She hopes that then, young men who see her will not fall in love with her just for her hair colour, but for herself alone. She wants to be loved for who she is inside, not for her looks.

Stanza 3:

*But all the king's horses and all the king's men
Cannot put the world back again,
Because love is not enough.
If the love were not for the self,
Love could not be enough
To hold the world together.*

→ In this stanza, Anne or the speaker says that no amount of power or force, suggested through all the king's horses and all the king's men, can change the

basic truth: outer beauty is not enough. If love is only for hair or colour and not for the real self, it cannot be strong enough to hold the world together. True love must go deeper.

Stanza 4:

*I heard an old religious man
But yesternight declare
That he had found a text to prove
That only God, my dear,
Could love you for yourself alone
And not your yellow hair.*

→ In the last stanza, the speaker remembers an old religious man who said that only God can love a person for themselves alone, and not just for their yellow hair or outer beauty. This means that human beings often fail to love purely, but God's love is perfect and loves the soul, not the appearance.

3. Key Literary Devices

- Metaphor: Honey-coloured ramparts describes Anne's beautiful hair like a strong, shining wall.
- Imagery: The poem creates a strong visual image of yellow hair and the idea of changing hair colour with dye.
- Symbolism: Yellow hair symbolises outer beauty; God's love symbolises pure, inner love.
- Rhyme and rhythm: Simple, clear rhyme and gentle rhythm make the poem easy to read.
- Contrast: The poem contrasts human love based on looks with God's love based on the inner self.

4. Moral

- Do not fall in love only with looks or hair colour; try to love the inner self.
- Outer beauty is temporary; inner character and soul are more important.
- True love means loving the person, not just their appearance.
- It is very rare for people to love purely; only God can love like this all the time.
- The poem teaches us to value inner beauty more than outer beauty.

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